

Running Time and Asymptotic Notation

Data Structures & Algorithms

Grading scheme:

- Homework 20%
- In-class quizzes 20% (2 lowest scores dropped)
- 2 exams 60%

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All announcements, grades, and homework will be posted on Canvas. Check it regularly.

Generative AI Usage Guidelines

- Asking **clarifying** questions related to lectures, homework, or exams is OK. Treat it as a tutor.
- For homework, you may use AI to do sanity checks on your solutions **without revealing the solution. See the syllabus for an example prompt.**

The homework is only 20% of your grade, so treat it as a learning opportunity.

I do believe that AI is a powerful tool that can help you learn, but it is not a substitute for learning itself.

My take

We will operate based on the premise that you believe in the value of learning.

- Grow cognitive skills by doing the work yourself
- Understanding is important for both academic and professional success
- There is value in learning in itself

An algorithm is a **precise, unambiguous** set of instructions that solves a problem.

Analyzing one has two parts:

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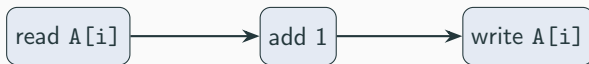
- Prove it is **correct**.
- Evaluate its **efficiency** — time, memory, ...

Running Time

Counting Instructions

Measure running time by the number of **basic machine instructions**: memory accesses, pairwise arithmetic.

$A[i] = A[i] + 1$



Count instructions **up to a constant factor**.

Selection Sort: The Idea

Scan $A[1:n]$ for the smallest element, put it in $A[1]$. Then scan $A[2:n]$, put its smallest in $A[2]$. And so on.

$j = 1$:

5	2	9	1	7
---	---	---	---	---

$j = 2$:

1	2	9	5	7
---	---	---	---	---

$j = 3$:

1	2	9	5	7
---	---	---	---	---

$j = 4$:

1	2	5	9	7
---	---	---	---	---

done:

1	2	5	7	9
---	---	---	---	---

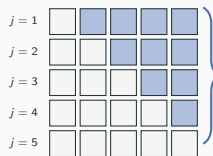
sorted prefix minimum of the rest

Selection Sort

```
function selection_sort!(A)
    n = length(A) # ln 1
    for j in 1:n-1 # ln 2
        min_idx = j # ln 3
        for k in j+1:n # ln 4
            if A[min_idx] > A[k] # ln 5
                min_idx = k # ln 6
            end
        end
        A[j], A[min_idx] = A[min_idx], A[j] # ln 7
    end
    return A
end
```

Counting the Lines

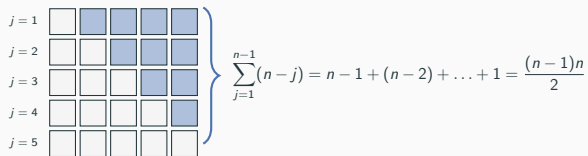
- Lines 1, 2, 3 run $n - 1$ times.
- Lines 4, 5, 6 run at most $(n - 1) + (n - 2) + \dots + 1$ times.
- Line 7 runs once.


$$\left. \begin{array}{l} j=1 \\ j=2 \\ j=3 \\ j=4 \\ j=5 \end{array} \right\} \sum_{j=1}^{n-1} (n-j) = n-1 + (n-2) + \dots + 1 = \frac{(n-1)n}{2}$$

Recall $1 + 2 + \dots + n = \frac{n(n+1)}{2}$.

Counting the Lines

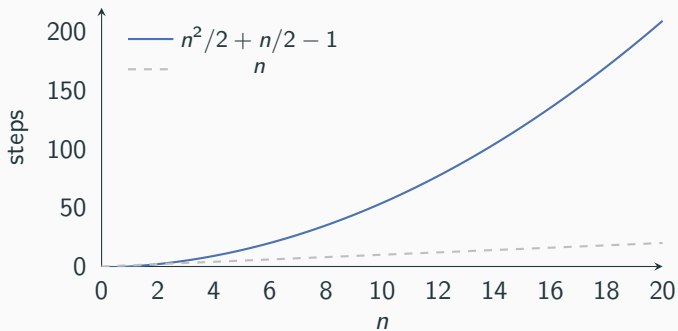
- Lines 1, 2, 3 run $n - 1$ times.
- Lines 4, 5, 6 run at most $(n - 1) + (n - 2) + \dots + 1$ times.
- Line 7 runs once.



Recall $1 + 2 + \dots + n = \frac{n(n+1)}{2}$.

Total

$$(n-1) + \frac{(n-1)n}{2} + 1 = O(n^2)$$



The running time grows **quadratically** in n .

Exercise

What is the running time of this function in terms of n ?

```
function dummy_algorithm(n)
  for j in 1:n
    x = 0
    for k in 1:2^j
      y = 1
    end
  end
end
```

Hint: geometric series

$$\sum_{i=0}^m r^i = \frac{r^{m+1} - 1}{r - 1}, \quad r \neq 1.$$

The inner loop runs 2^j times for each j . So the total work is

$$\sum_{j=1}^n 2^j = \left(\sum_{j=0}^n 2^j \right) - 1 = \frac{2^{n+1} - 1}{2 - 1} - 1 = 2^{n+1} - 2.$$

Answer

$O(2^n)$ — the last iteration alone dominates everything before it.

Asymptotic Notation

Why Asymptotics

For $T(n) = n^2/2 + n/2 - 1$, the term n^2 **dictates** the growth.

$$\frac{n^2}{2}$$

dominant

$$\frac{n}{2}$$

noise

$$-1$$

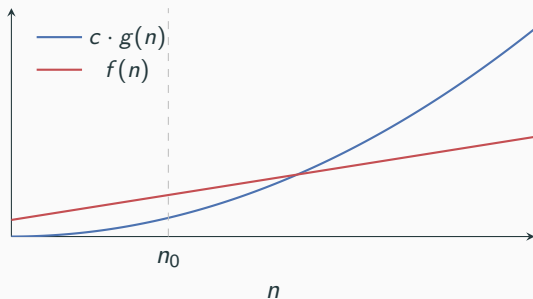
noise

We write $f(n) = O(g(n))$ to say: f grows **no more** than g .

Definition

$f(n) = O(g(n))$ if there exist constants $c > 0$ and n_0 such that

$$f(n) \leq c \cdot g(n) \quad \text{for all } n \geq n_0.$$



Example

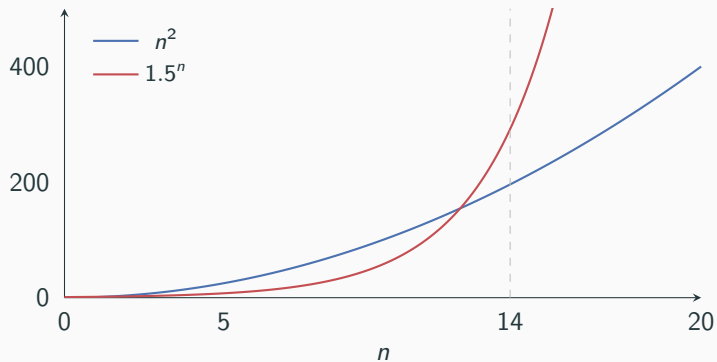
$$3n^2 + 5n + 10 = O(n^2)$$

Take $c = 18$ and $n_0 = 1$. For $n \geq 1$:

$$3n^2 + 5n + 10 \leq 3n^2 + 5n^2 + 10n^2 = 18n^2.$$

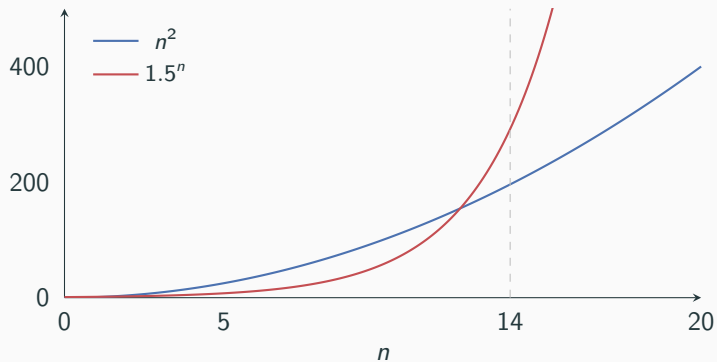
Example: $n^2 = O(1.5^n)$

Take $c = 1$ and $n_0 = 14$.



Example: $n^2 = O(1.5^n)$

Take $c = 1$ and $n_0 = 14$.



From $n = 14$ onward, $n^2 \leq 1.5^n$.

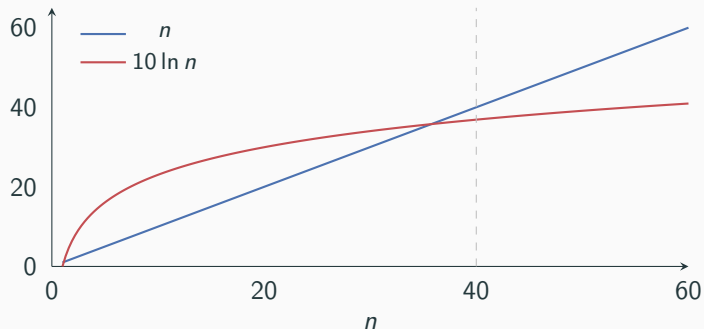
The Limit Approach

If $\lim_{n \rightarrow \infty} \frac{f(n)}{g(n)} = \text{constant} < \infty$, then $f(n) = O(g(n))$.

Example:

$$\lim_{n \rightarrow \infty} \frac{n^2/2 + n/2 - 1}{n^2} = \lim_{n \rightarrow \infty} \left(\frac{1}{2} + \frac{1}{2n} - \frac{1}{n^2} \right) = \frac{1}{2}.$$

Example: $n + 10 \ln n = O(n)$



For $n \geq 40$ we have $10 \ln n \leq n$, hence

$$n + 10 \ln n \leq n + n = 2n \quad (c = 2, n_0 = 40).$$

L'Hôpital's rule

If $\lim f'(n)/g'(n)$ exists, then $\lim \frac{f(n)}{g(n)} = \lim \frac{f'(n)}{g'(n)}$.

$$\lim_{n \rightarrow \infty} \frac{n + 10 \ln n}{n} = \lim_{n \rightarrow \infty} \frac{1 + 10/n}{1} = 1 < \infty.$$

1. Show that $\log_a n = O(\log_b n)$ for constants a, b .

Hint: change-of-base formula.

2. Show that $2\sqrt{n} + n^{1/3} \log_2 n = O(\sqrt{n})$.

Solution 1

Change of base: $\log_a n = \frac{\log_b n}{\log_b a}$.

Since $\log_b a$ is a **constant**, take $c = 1/\log_b a$ and $n_0 = 1$:

$$\log_a n = c \cdot \log_b n \leq c \cdot \log_b n.$$

The base of a logarithm never matters inside $O(\cdot)$.

Solution 2

We need $n^{1/3} \log_2 n$ to be swallowed by $\sqrt{n} = n^{1/2}$:

$$\frac{n^{1/3} \log_2 n}{n^{1/2}} = \frac{\log_2 n}{n^{1/6}} \xrightarrow{n \rightarrow \infty} 0,$$

since a polynomial beats a logarithm.

So $n^{1/3} \log_2 n \leq \sqrt{n}$ for large n , giving

$$2\sqrt{n} + n^{1/3} \log_2 n \leq 3\sqrt{n} \quad (c = 3).$$

Definition

$g(n) = \Omega(f(n))$ if $f(n) = O(g(n))$.

$$f(n) = O(g(n))$$

grows **no faster** than g

$$f(n) = \Omega(g(n))$$

grows **no slower** than g

Definition

$f(n) = \Theta(g(n))$ if $f(n) = O(g(n))$ and $g(n) = O(f(n))$.

Equivalently, via limits:

$$0 < \lim_{n \rightarrow \infty} \frac{f(n)}{g(n)} < \infty.$$

Neither function grows strictly faster than the other.

Example: $2n^{100} + n^{99} = \Theta(n^{100})$

$$\lim_{n \rightarrow \infty} \frac{2n^{100} + n^{99}}{n^{100}} = 2 \quad \implies \quad 2n^{100} + n^{99} = O(n^{100}).$$

$$\lim_{n \rightarrow \infty} \frac{n^{100}}{2n^{100} + n^{99}} = \lim_{n \rightarrow \infty} \frac{1}{2 + 1/n} = \frac{1}{2} \quad \implies \quad n^{100} = O(2n^{100} + n^{99}).$$

Both directions hold, so the two functions have the **same growth**.

1. Show that $n^{1.99} = O(n^2)$ but $n^{1.99} \neq \Theta(n^2)$.
2. Show that if n is a power of 2, then $2 + 4 + 8 + \dots + n = \Theta(n)$.

Solution 1

Upper bound. $\lim_{n \rightarrow \infty} \frac{n^{1.99}}{n^2} = \lim_{n \rightarrow \infty} n^{-0.01} = 0 < \infty$, so $n^{1.99} = O(n^2)$.

Not Θ . For Θ we would also need $n^2 = O(n^{1.99})$, but

$$\lim_{n \rightarrow \infty} \frac{n^2}{n^{1.99}} = \lim_{n \rightarrow \infty} n^{0.01} = \infty.$$

No constant c can satisfy $n^2 \leq c n^{1.99}$ for all large n . In fact $n^{1.99} = o(n^2)$.

Solution 2

Write $n = 2^m$. The sum is a geometric series:

$$2 + 4 + \dots + 2^m = \left(\sum_{i=0}^m 2^i \right) - 1 = \frac{2^{m+1} - 1}{2 - 1} - 1 = 2 \cdot 2^m - 2 = 2n - 2.$$

Since $n \leq 2n - 2 \leq 2n$ for $n \geq 2$, the sum is $\Theta(n)$.

A doubling sum is dominated by its **last** term.

Little- o and Little- ω

Definition

$f(n) = o(g(n))$ if for *any* constant $c > 0$ there is n_0 with $f(n) < c \cdot g(n)$ for all $n \geq n_0$.

Equivalently $\lim_{n \rightarrow \infty} \frac{f(n)}{g(n)} = 0$.

Definition

$f(n) = \omega(g(n))$ if $g(n) = o(f(n))$. Equivalently $\lim_{n \rightarrow \infty} \frac{f(n)}{g(n)} = \infty$.

Strictly slower and strictly faster growth.

Claim: $\log_2 n = o(n^{0.1})$.

$$\lim_{n \rightarrow \infty} \frac{\log_2 n}{n^{0.1}} = \frac{1}{\ln 2} \lim_{n \rightarrow \infty} \frac{\ln n}{n^{0.1}} = \frac{1}{\ln 2} \lim_{n \rightarrow \infty} \frac{1/n}{0.1 n^{-0.9}} = \frac{1}{\ln 2} \lim_{n \rightarrow \infty} \frac{10}{n^{0.1}} = 0.$$

Claim: $3^n = \omega(2^n)$.

$$\lim_{n \rightarrow \infty} \frac{3^n}{2^n} = \lim_{n \rightarrow \infty} (3/2)^n = \infty.$$

Recap

$f(n) = O(g(n))$	growth at most g
$f(n) = \Omega(g(n))$	growth at least g
$f(n) = \Theta(g(n))$	growth the same as g
$f(n) = o(g(n))$	growth strictly slower than g
$f(n) = \omega(g(n))$	growth strictly faster than g



Useful Facts

Fact 1: Polynomials

A polynomial grows like its **most significant term**:

$$3n^3 - n^2 + 100n = \Theta(n^3).$$

A polynomial always beats a poly-logarithm:

$$n = \omega(\log^{999} n),$$

$$n^{0.1} = \omega(\log^{99} n),$$

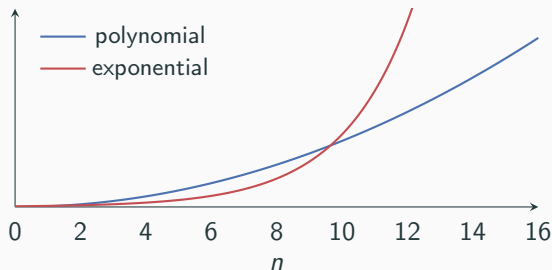
$$n \log^2 n = o(n^{1.01}).$$

Fact 2: Exponentials

An exponential (base > 1) always beats a polynomial:

$$n^{99} = o(2^n),$$

$$n^{10} = o(1.01^{2^n}).$$



Fact 3: Power Sums

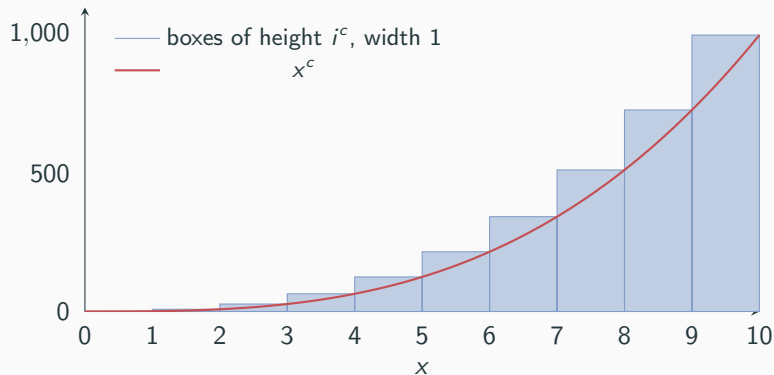
For any constant c : $1^c + 2^c + \dots + n^c = \Theta(n^{c+1})$.

Upper bound. Every term is at most n^c :

$$1^c + 2^c + \dots + n^c \leq \underbrace{n^c + n^c + \dots + n^c}_{n \text{ times}} = n^{c+1}.$$

So the sum is $O(n^{c+1})$. The lower bound needs more work.

Approximation by Integrals



Box area = $1^c + 2^c + \dots + n^c \geq$ area under the curve.

Fact 3: Lower Bound

Each box at position i has width 1 and height i^c , so the boxes cover the curve:

$$1^c + 2^c + \dots + n^c \geq \int_0^n x^c dx = \frac{n^{c+1}}{c+1}.$$

Hence the sum is $\Omega(n^{c+1})$, and combined with the upper bound,

$$1^c + 2^c + \dots + n^c = \Theta(n^{c+1}).$$

$$\text{E.g. } 1^2 + 2^2 + \dots + n^2 = \Theta(n^3).$$

Fact 4

For any constant c , $c = O(1)$.

Fact 5

If $a < b$, then $a^n = o(b^n)$. E.g. $2^n = o(3^n)$.

A Common Pitfall

The following proof is **wrong**:

$$1 + 2 + 3 + \dots + n = O(1) + O(1) + \dots + O(1) = O(n).$$

But we know $1 + 2 + \dots + n = \frac{n(n+1)}{2} = \Theta(n^2)$.

What went wrong

For a *fixed* i , yes, $i = O(1)$.

Inside $\sum_{i=1}^n i$, the value i ranges up to n — it is **not** a constant.

Be careful with sums whose number of terms is not fixed.